

Race and philosophy



Despite American political philosophy's preoccupation with democracy, African-Americans remained second-class citizens even after the Civil War and abolition of slavery. The struggle for civil rights was spearheaded by W.E.B. Du Bois, founder of the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) in 1909, and culminated with Martin Luther King's political campaign in the 1960s, making race and racism important issues for political philosophy. Black American thinkers also helped encourage African nations in their struggle for independence. Martinique-born existentialist Frantz Fanon was among the first post-colonial African

philosophers, and emphasized the idea of a nation choosing an identity for itself. Many newly independent nations opted to model themselves on Western democracies, others chose Marxist-inspired socialist republics – but underlying all was a sense of freedom from European rule. Later, a distinctly African philosophical movement evolved, incorporating traditional ideas, but highlighting issues of poverty and deprivation, as well as race and oppression.